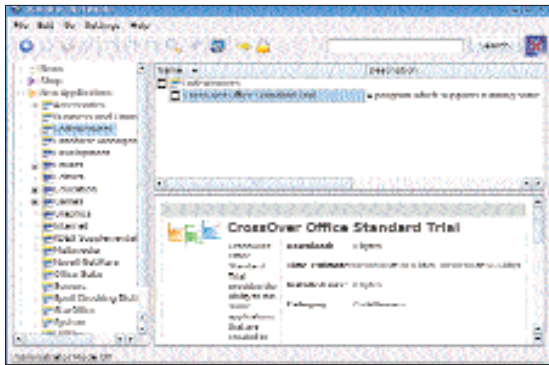




Xandros networks makes software updating effortless

Conclusion

We found both these products quite suited for a new Linux user and recommending a single product is difficult. Both these products are neck-and-neck in terms of features and performance; however, we do think Xandros has something more to offer than Linspire.

Overall, it's a personal choice; if you value eye-candy, Linspire beats Xandros hands down, but if you want practicality then Xandros is the way to go.

Also keep in mind that you need to buy them. While Xandros Desktop OS 3 Deluxe edition is available for \$90, Linspire 5.0 with one year CNR membership retails for around the same price. If you want to try these products, they are available on their respective Web sites for download.

LINUX FOR POWER USERS

In this category, we have Ubuntu 5.04, Fedora Core 4, RedHat WS, SuSe 9.3 professional, Mandrake 10.1 and OpenLx 11.

While Fedora has been the distro that most power users swear by, in recent times, Ubuntu has seen remarkable acceptance by the community and happens to be the number one according to www.distrowatch.com poll.

SuSe 9.3, RedHat WS and Mandrake 10.1 have corporate backing and hence are driven by dedicated teams of developers as against the community driven project such as Fedora and Ubuntu.

OpenLx comes from an Indian developer and is based on Fedora core. These distros are targeted at mature Linux audiences that prefer the DIY (do-it-yourself) approach over spoon-feeding. Hence, ease of use, though desired, is not the defining factor as to which is better.

On the other hand, it does not mean that a new Linux user can't try them, but don't expect things to work for you out of the box, a little tweaking here and there will be required.

Installation

Since you have enough experience and confidence on installing these Linux distro's, we think we need to touch up on the important issues without going into the depth of installation as we did for the beginners.

A true blue Linux user is at complete ease with a command line interface (CLI), for he has not only learned to live with it but also to love it. While this is true, a GUI installer wouldn't hurt.

Ubuntu was the only distro in this comparison to come without a GUI-based interface. Though it doesn't hamper the work, we would love to see a nice, simple, point-and-click UI.

Fedora 4, RedHat and the Fedora-based OpenLx come in second when it comes to ease of installation. One good feature they have is to check the installation media for any errors before you actually start the installation. While installing Fedora, we found that CDs 3 and 4 were corrupt. Because we used this disc check feature, we saved a lot of trouble and time.

SuSe and Mandrake have always been ahead of their time, innovating features that make life simpler. Keeping with the tradition, their latest products have the same sleek installer that will win

accolades. We think SuSe has done commendable work on their YaST2 (Yet another Setup Tool) module, which is simply fantastic to use.

Apart from Ubuntu, all other distro's here will allow you to choose the packages to install. Is that bad? Not really, since Ubuntu comes on a single CD-ROM while all other distros come on a minimum of four CD-ROMs. So there is nothing much left to choose or discard in Ubuntu—what you get is a fairly configured system.

Partitioning, again, is much simpler in SuSe and Mandrake as compared to Ubuntu, Fedora or OpenLx. The primary reason being the amount of attention paid towards convenience.

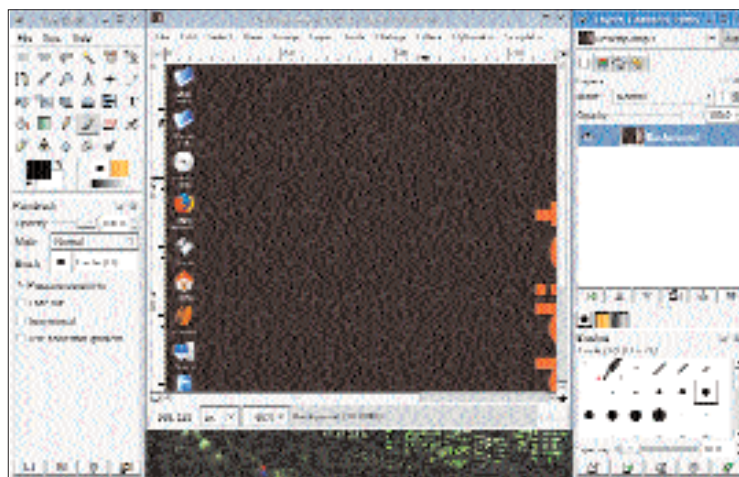
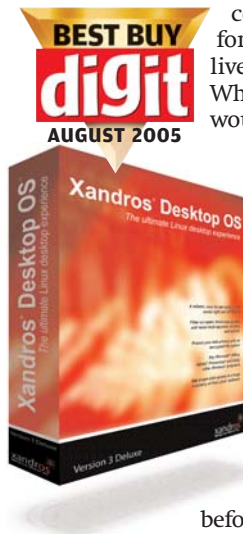
However, bear in mind that although other distros have workable user interfaces, there is still a lot of scope for improvement.

Overall, when it comes to ease of installation it is SuSe that takes centre stage. Its sleek, simple to use interface and granularity in offering control over the installation procedure gives it an edge over other distros.

Post Installation

After installing the files, Ubuntu offers to configure your video display and prompts the user for the appropriate resolution to use—we found this really helpful. Once done, a pleasant looking coffee coloured Gnome desktop tickles your senses. "Wow! This is neat...", are the words most people use to describe it.

Ubuntu was the only distro that defaulted to Gnome's 2.10 (geeky) environment—all other distro's invariably use KDE (K Desktop Environment).



The new Gimp 2.2, an Image manipulator for Linux is bundled with OpenLx, SuSe 9.3, Fedora Core 4, Ubuntu etc.